



FOOD FOR THOUGHT

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The risks of increased oil consumption

While dietary fats are **essential for nutrient absorption**, hormone production, and brain function, too much oil — especially from the wrong sources — leads to inflammation, weight gain, and metabolic disorders.

In a country where deep-fried delicacies and rich curries are an intrinsic part of daily meals, the idea of cutting down on oil may seem impractical. However, when our Hon'ble Prime Minister speaks on the subject, it is more than just dietary advice — it becomes a national health movement.

At the 38th National Games in Dehradun on January 28, 2025, Shri Narendra Modi addressed an often-overlooked health issue: excessive oil consumption. He linked it to rising lifestyle disorders such as obesity, diabetes, and heart disease, urging people to reduce oil intake by just 10 per cent. His message aligns with the *Economic Survey 2023-24*, which warns of the economic burden of unhealthy diets and sedentary lifestyles.

The hidden impact of excessive oil consumption

Globally, India ranks among the highest in obesity and diabetes cases. According to the National Family Health Survey (NFHS-5), obesity rates have surged due to high-calorie diets loaded with refined oils and processed foods. This issue is not just limited to the general population — it also affects athletes, where nutrition directly impacts performance.

As a nutritionist working with elite athletes and fitness enthusiasts, I have witnessed firsthand how excess oil affects endurance, agility, and recovery. While dietary fats are essential for nutrient absorption, hormone production, and brain function, too much oil — especially from the wrong sources — leads to inflammation, weight gain, and metabolic disorders.

Indian diets rely heavily on refined vegetable oils such as sunflower, soybean, and palm oil. These are high in Omega-6 fatty acids, which, in excess, create chronic

inflammation and increase the risk of heart disease and joint issues. For athletes, excess oil slows muscle recovery, and for everyday individuals, it contributes to sluggish digestion, poor gut health, and higher LDL cholesterol.

Shri Modi's recommendation to cut back by just 10 per cent may seem small, but consistent reduction can significantly improve weight management, cardiovascular health, and metabolic function.

Can you reduce oil without losing flavour?

Yes! A major challenge in reducing oil intake is changing cooking habits. Indian cuisine is built around oil-heavy techniques, from deep-frying to heavy tempering (*tadka*). However, small, practical changes can help:

- ✦ Use non-stick cookware to minimise oil usage.
- ✦ Brush oil instead of pouring it to control portions.
- ✦ Air-fry instead of deep-frying to maintain crispness with less fat.
- ✦ Roast spices before tempering to release their natural flavours.
- ✦ Enhance flavours naturally with herbs, lemon juice, and dry-roasted spices.